THE HOPE CONNECTION

Episode Lessons

Daily and Weekly Lessons from the Podcast — Phase 1: Episodes 1–5 & Rachel's "My Story"

> "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope."
>
> Romans 15:13 (ESV)

From The Hope Connection with Lewis Fuller — the Episode Lesson Bank

"Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus"

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The Hope Connection — Episode Lesson Bank: Framework

Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus

What this is

Every episode of The Hope Connection yields **one weekly lesson** and **five daily lessons**. The weekly lesson is the deep study — for the person or family who can sit down once a week and dig in. The daily lessons are the short ones — one verse, one true thing, one question, one prayer — for the days in between. Some people are fed best a little at a time, every day. Others are fed best in one deep sitting each week. Both doors are open, and both lead down the same road.

The source rule

Lessons are drawn **from the episode itself** — its script, its transcript, its show content — never invented around it. The teaching in a lesson is the teaching of the episode, carried into study form in Lewis's plain voice. Words placed in quotation marks as Lewis's or Rachel's own are quoted from the episode source. Scripture is quoted from the English Standard Version (ESV), verbatim, with its reference.

Each episode's entry in index.md records exactly which source its lessons rest on — full script, transcript, show notes, or description — so nothing in this bank pretends to be more than it is.

The audience rule (Lewis, Nov 4, 2026 — binding)

These lessons are for **whoever is struggling** — women, men, children, teenagers, anyone. They are never framed as men-only or adults-only. The language is plain and warm: a teenager can read it, and a grandmother can sit with it. Second person, gentle, Christ-centered. The bad news is told honestly; the good news always lands.

The formats

Daily lesson (~150–200 words)

- Title
- *From Episode N: [episode title]*
- Anchor verse (ESV, verbatim, with reference)

- 3–5 sentences of teaching drawn from the episode
- One question to sit with
- A one-line prayer

Five per episode, each on a distinct moment or passage of the episode.

Weekly lesson (~600–800 words)

- Title
- Episode and series
- The passage (ESV)
- The teaching in 3 clear points, drawn from the episode
- 3 questions for reflection or family/group talk
- A closing prayer
- Sign-off: *Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.*

How lessons release alongside episodes

- **Recorded episodes:** lessons are built from the episode's script or transcript and release with the episode.
- **Unrecorded episodes:** lessons may be *staged* from the finished script ahead of recording, but they do not release until the episode itself lands — the lesson always follows the voice it came from.
- The bank lives as the one complete home of the lessons (blog/Library pattern): platforms carry the invitation; the bank carries the study.

The phase plan

- **Phase 1 (this build):** Episodes 1–5 plus the bonus special, Rachel's "My Story" — every episode currently published.
- **Phase 2:** Episodes 6–8 (Surrender, Parts 2–3, and The Roller Coaster of Life) as they publish.
- **Phase 3 onward:** each built series in season order — Make No Peace With Sin (Eps 9–12), The Exchanged Life (Eps 13–16), God Is Not Mocked (Eps 17–20), Faith (Eps 21–24), Trust the Process (Eps 25–28) — one phase per series, staged from scripts, released episode by episode.

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Episode Lesson Bank — Index (Phase 1: Episodes 1–5 + Bonus)

One weekly lesson + five daily lessons per episode, drawn from the episode itself. See framework.md for the formats, the source rule, and the audience rule.

Source inventory (honest record)

Episode	Source used	Strength
Ep 1 — Welcome to The Hope Connection	**Full episode script** (hope-connection-intro-script.txt) + published show description	Strong — a complete written script exists (the published audio is a 1:07 welcome cut of it)
Ep 2 — There Is Hope (My Testimony)	**Full episode script/transcript** (lewis-fuller-testimony-clean.txt, ~3,700 words)	Strong
Ep 3 — Abounding Hope	**Show notes + episode content suite** (03-abounding-hope-notes.txt; episode-suites/abounding-hope.md) — *no full episode script survives*	**Medium — flagged:** lessons rest on the episode's own show notes, its Romans 15:13 anchor, and its produced companion content, not a verbatim script
Ep 4 — What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?	**Full episode script** (hope-connection-real-surrender-script.md)	Strong
Ep 5 — Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over	**Full episode script** (hope-connection-surrender-part-1-script.md)	Strong
Bonus — My Story: Rachel's Testimony	**Full episode transcript** (rachel-episode-transcript.txt, auto-generated; minor transcription garble in places — lessons quote only lines that are clear in context)	Strong

Lessons built

Episode 1 — Welcome to The Hope Connection (episode-01-welcome/)

- **Weekly:** Come As You Are: The Welcome That Changes Everything (Matthew 11:28; Romans 15:13)

- **Dailies:** 1. You Don't Have to Clean Up First (Matt 11:28) · 2. Hope Begins With God, Not With Us (Rom 15:13) · 3. Hope Has a Name (Rom 5:8) · 4. Honest About Where We Are (Luke 19:10) · 5. Leave Anchored (Heb 6:19)
- Status: built, Phase 1

Episode 2 — There Is Hope (My Testimony) (episode-02-there-is-hope/)

- **Weekly:** Knowing God, Not Just About Him (John 17:3, 17:20)
- **Dailies:** 1. He Prayed for You Before You Existed (John 17:20) · 2. Knowing About God Is Not Knowing God (John 17:3) · 3. "My Way" Promised Freedom and Delivered a Cage (Prov 14:12) · 4. But God (Rom 5:8) · 5. "Anyone" Means Anyone (2 Cor 5:17)
- Status: built, Phase 1

Episode 3 — Abounding Hope (episode-03-abounding-hope/)

- **Weekly:** Hope That Overflows (Romans 15:13)
- **Dailies:** 1. More Than a Wish (Rom 15:13) · 2. Filled, Not Just Topped Up (Ps 23:5) · 3. Hope Holds Like an Anchor (Heb 6:19) · 4. Joy and Peace *in Believing* (John 14:27) · 5. Overflow Is Meant to Be Shared (2 Cor 1:3–4)
- Status: built, Phase 1 — source flagged medium (see inventory)

Episode 4 — What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like? (episode-04-real-surrender/)

- **Weekly:** Not My Will: Surrender in the Garden (Luke 22:42)
- **Dailies:** 1. Honest First (Ps 62:8) · 2. Giving Over Is Not Giving Up (Gal 2:20) · 3. Every One to His Own Way (Isa 53:6) · 4. He Handed Himself Over First (Rom 8:32) · 5. A Living Sacrifice Crawls Off the Altar (Luke 9:23)
- Status: built, Phase 1

Episode 5 — Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over (episode-05-surrender-part-1/)

- **Weekly:** The Grip: Why We Won't Open Our Hands (Luke 22:42)
- **Dailies:** 1. The Plan You Can't Release (Prov 16:9) · 2. Handing a Person to God Is Not Abandoning Them (Ps 55:22) · 3. A Fortress With the Prisoner Inside (Isa 41:10) · 4. The

Decision Goes First; Feelings Report Later (2 Cor 5:7) · 5. Thirty Years Late Is Not Late to God (Luke 15:20)

- Status: built, Phase 1

Bonus Special — My Story: Rachel's Testimony (episode-bonus-rachel-my-story/)

- **Weekly:** Leave It With Him: Learning to Stop Picking the Burden Back Up (Matthew 11:28; 1 Peter 5:6–7)
- **Dailies:** 1. Bone Tired Is a Real Place (Matt 11:28) · 2. Lay It Down — Again (1 Pet 5:7) · 3. Still in the Storm (Ps 46:10–11) · 4. Strength for the Road You're On (Isa 40:31) · 5. God Doesn't Waste Your Pain (Rom 8:28)
- Status: built, Phase 1 (bonus)

Phase 1 totals

- **6 weekly lessons, 30 daily lessons — 36 lessons.**
- Compiled in phase-1-lessons.pdf.

Come As You Are: The Welcome That Changes Everything

Weekly Lesson — Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection" · The Hope Connection, Season 1

The passage:

> "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." — Matthew 11:28 (ESV)

> "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope." — Romans 15:13 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. You don't clean up first. Most of us learn to say "I am fine" when we are not — tired, discouraged, ashamed, or unsure — and sometimes that pressure follows us right into church, as if we had to get ourselves together before we could come near to God. But that is not the invitation Jesus gives. He does not say, "Fix yourself, and then come." He says, "Come to me." He meets weary people *as* weary people, and He receives sinners who know they need mercy. Whatever you are carrying today — disappointment, loneliness, fear, or questions you have not known how to put into words — you are welcome here, and more than that, you are welcome to *Him*, exactly as you are.

2. Hope here is not a wish — it has a name. When the Bible speaks about hope, it means more than wishing tomorrow might be easier. Biblical hope is confident trust in who God is and what He has promised. Notice where Romans 15:13 says hope begins: not in us, but in *the God of hope*. We do not manufacture hope by thinking positive thoughts. God fills His people with joy and peace as they trust Him, and the Holy Spirit causes that hope to overflow. And that hope has a name: Jesus. The center of the message is not that good people can improve their lives. It is that God loved sinners and sent His Son to save them — so guilt does not have the final word, suffering does not have the final word, and even death does not have the final word.

3. Leave anchored. This show exists to be a place where we can be honest about where we are while refusing to believe that where we are is the end of the story. That is what an anchor does: it holds a boat steady in water that is anything but steady. You do not have to pretend your pain is small. You only have to remember that Jesus is greater. Come as you are — and Lord willing, leave anchored.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. Where in your life have you been saying "I am fine" when you are not? What would it mean to bring that place honestly to Jesus instead of hiding it?
2. 2. When you hear the word "hope," do you hear a wish or a confidence? What is the difference, and which one have you been living on?
3. 3. Jesus says, "Come to me." What is one burden you can bring to Him this week exactly as you are — before anything about it changes?

Closing prayer:

Father, thank You that Your invitation is "come," not "clean up first." You know the weight each of us carried into this day — the tiredness we hide, the questions we cannot phrase, the parts of life that feel too messy to bring near You. Teach us to come anyway. Fill us with the joy and peace that come from trusting You, and let Your hope overflow in us by the power of Your Spirit. Anchor us in Jesus, who is greater than everything we face. In His name we pray, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Episode 1 — Daily Lessons

Daily 1 — You Don't Have to Clean Up First

From Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection"

> "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." — Matthew 11:28 (ESV)

So many of us believe we have to get ourselves together before we can come near to God — fix the habit, quiet the mess, feel a little more respectable. But that is not the invitation Jesus gives. He does not say, "Fix yourself, and then come." He says, "Come to me." He meets weary people as weary people, and He receives anyone who knows they need mercy. Whatever you are carrying today, you do not have to set it in order before you bring it to Him. You bring it *to* Him, and He gives rest.

Question: What is the one thing you have been trying to fix before you would let yourself come to Jesus with it?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, I come to You as I am today — tired and unfinished — trusting that You receive me and give rest. Amen.

Daily 2 — Hope Begins With God, Not With Us

From Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection"

> "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope." — Romans 15:13 (ESV)

Notice where this verse says hope begins: not in us, but in *the God of hope*. We do not manufacture hope by thinking positive thoughts or trying harder to feel optimistic. God fills His people with joy and peace as they trust Him, and the Holy Spirit causes that hope to abound — to overflow. That means on the day your own supply feels empty, you are not at the end of hope. You are simply at the place where hope was always meant to come from: Him, not you.

Question: Have you been trying to produce hope out of your own strength? What would it look like to ask the God of hope to fill you instead?

Prayer: God of hope, fill me today with joy and peace in believing, by the power of Your Holy Spirit. Amen.

Daily 3 — Hope Has a Name

From Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection"

> "But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." — Romans 5:8 (ESV)

Biblical hope is not a mood and it is not a strategy. It has a name: Jesus. The center of the Christian message is not that good people can improve their lives — it is that God loved sinners and sent His Son to save them. Jesus died for us *while we were still sinners* — not after we improved, not once we deserved it. Because He lives, guilt does not have the final word over your life. Suffering does not have the final word. Even death does not have the final word. A Person does — and He loves you.

Question: When your hope feels thin, do you turn to a feeling, a plan, or a Person? What changes when hope has a name?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, thank You that You died for me while I was still a sinner; help me put my hope in You, not in my circumstances. Amen.

Daily 4 — Honest About Where We Are

From Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection"

> "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." — Luke 19:10 (ESV)

We live in a world where people feel pressure to appear strong. We learn to say "I am fine" even when we are discouraged, angry, ashamed, or unsure. But Jesus came to seek and to save the *lost* — He came looking for people who do not have it together. This is a place for honest conversation: we tell the truth about where we are, while refusing to believe that where we are is the end of the story. You do not need a better story to be found by Him. You only need the one you are actually living.

Question: Where have you been hiding behind "I am fine"? What is the honest sentence you could say to God today?

Prayer: Father, I stop pretending with You; meet me in the honest place, and write the next part of my story. Amen.

Daily 5 — Leave Anchored

From Episode 1: "Welcome to The Hope Connection"

> "We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain." — Hebrews 6:19 (ESV)

An anchor does not calm the sea. It holds the boat steady in a sea that is anything but steady. That is what hope in Jesus does for a life. The waves may keep coming — hard news, hard days, hard memories — but a soul anchored in Christ is held by something stronger than the weather. The invitation of this whole show is short enough to carry with you: come as you are, and Lord willing, leave anchored. Not pretending the storm is small. Just held by the One who is greater than it.

Question: What storm is loudest in your life right now — and what would it mean to be held steady in it, rather than waiting for it to stop before you trust God?

Prayer: Lord, anchor my soul in You today; hold me steady in the waters I cannot calm. Amen.

Knowing God, Not Just About Him

Weekly Lesson — Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)" · The Hope Connection, Season 1

The passage:

> "And this is eternal life, that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent." — John 17:3 (ESV)

> "I do not ask for these only, but also for those who will believe in me through their word." — John 17:20 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. Eternal life is knowing a Person. On the night before the cross, Jesus prayed out loud — for Himself, for His disciples, and then, in verse 20, for everyone who would ever believe through their word. That includes you. And listen to how He defines eternal life: not first a place, and not mainly about living forever, but *knowing* — "that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent." The word does not mean knowing *about* someone. You can know about a president without ever meeting him. This is personal, living knowledge — the way you know a close friend. Eternal life is not a reward you earn by cleaning up your act. It is a relationship you receive by grace.

2. "My way" promises freedom and delivers a cage. Lewis was raised by his grandparents; his grandmother took him to church, and the foundation stayed with him. But around eighteen or nineteen he wanted his own life, on his own terms — and that one decision led to trouble with the law and more than thirty years of hard-drug addiction. Thirty years of knowing better and doing worse anyway. He studied Scripture, even tried Bible college online; he went through rehabs, AA, and NA — and still felt empty, different, alone, with no peace for a day, not for an hour. His own diagnosis is the honest one: "My problem was not mainly the drugs… My problem was that I wanted my way." Knowledge filled his head while his heart stayed dead — proof that information does not save anyone.

3. But God. Those are the two most hopeful words in Scripture. Lewis walked into the Haven of Rest discipleship program four times and walked back out four times — and God was not done with him after four. The last time, something had changed: a real hunger, not to know *about* God, but to know *Him*. Reading John 17 one day — verses 3 and 20 — "it was as if a light lit up in my head. I understood what it said. I believed it." The old Lewis did not get renovated; a new man was raised. And the promise that met him still stands for anyone seeking: God "rewards those who seek him" (Hebrews 11:6) — and the reward is not mainly a fixed life. The reward is *Him*.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. Be honest: do you mostly know *about* God, or do you know Him? What is the difference, and where do you see it in your own life?
2. 2. Jesus prayed in John 17:20 for "those who will believe in me through their word" — two thousand years before you were born. What does it do to your heart to know you were prayed for before you existed?
3. 3. Lewis failed four times at the same program before the change came. Is there a number — of failures, of years, of tries — you have been treating as proof God is done with you? What does this story say to that number?

Closing prayer:

Father, thank You that You prayed for us before we ever sought You — that Jesus had us on His heart the night before He died for us. For the one who knows a lot about You but does not yet know You, close that distance today. For the one who feels empty, alone, and out of tries, show them that You are a rewarder of those who seek You, and that the reward is Yourself. Give us hearts that do not just learn about You, but know You. In Jesus' name, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Episode 2 — Daily Lessons

Daily 1 — He Prayed for You Before You Existed

From Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)"

> "I do not ask for these only, but also for those who will believe in me through their word." — John 17:20 (ESV)

On the night before He died, Jesus prayed for His disciples — and then He looked further down the road than anyone in the room could see, and prayed for everyone who would believe through their word. That is you. Two thousand years before you were born, your believing was on the lips of Jesus. You cannot be forgotten by Someone who prayed for you before you existed. When the voice in your head says nobody cares and your case is hopeless, there is an answer older than your pain: Jesus prayed for me.

Question: What changes in your heart when you realize you were prayed for before you were born?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, thank You that You prayed for me before I existed; let me live today inside that prayer. Amen.

Daily 2 — Knowing About God Is Not Knowing God

From Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)"

> "And this is eternal life, that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent." — John 17:3 (ESV)

There is a universe of difference between knowing *about* God and knowing God. A person can sit in church for years, memorize verses, study hard, even finish Bible courses — and still not know Him. Lewis did all of it, with the words in his head and emptiness in his chest. Jesus defines eternal life as *knowing* — personal, living knowledge, the way you know a close friend. Eternal life is not first a place you go. It is a Person you know, and He can be known today, by you, for real.

Question: Honestly — has your faith been mostly information about God, or a living knowledge of Him? What is one honest prayer you can pray about that today?

Prayer: Father, I don't want to only know about You; teach me to know You. Amen.

Daily 3 — "My Way" Promised Freedom and Delivered a Cage

From Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)"

> "There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death." — Proverbs 14:12 (ESV)

At eighteen or nineteen, Lewis wanted his own life on his own terms. It sounded like freedom. It delivered thirty years of addiction, broken promises, and a life that got smaller while the drugs got bigger. His own verdict is worth sitting with: "My way sounds like freedom. It is actually a prison. I built my own cell, locked the door from the inside, and called it independence." Sin always over-promises and under-delivers — it tells you that you are in control right up until the day you realize you have not been in control for years.

Question: Where has "my way" been promising you freedom lately? What has it actually delivered?

Prayer: Lord, show me where my own way is caging me, and turn my feet toward Yours. Amen.

Daily 4 — But God

From Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)"

> "But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." — Romans 5:8 (ESV)

Lewis's whole story turns on two small words: *but God*. He felt empty, alone, and abandoned — as if even God had finally given up on him. He was wrong. While he was still running, God was pursuing him the whole time. God did not wait for him to get clean, fix his record, or prove himself. "While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Here is what that means for you today: you do not have to get your life together before you come to Him. That is backwards. You come to Him *because* you cannot get it together.

Question: What part of your life have you been waiting to fix before coming to God? What if He is asking you to bring it as it is?

Prayer: Father, thank You that while I was still a sinner, Christ died for me; I come to You today as I am. Amen.

Daily 5 — "Anyone" Means Anyone

From Episode 2: "There Is Hope (My Testimony)"

> "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come." — 2 Corinthians 5:17 (ESV)

That word *anyone* has no exceptions — not for people with records, not for people with addictions, not for people who have failed four times or forty. Lewis had his list of reasons grace could not reach him: thirty years, no diploma, four failed attempts at the same program. The list was wrong. Grace reached further than his list. The old life is not patched up or improved — it passes away, and something genuinely new comes. Your worst chapter is not your final chapter when Christ holds the pen.

Question: What is on your list of reasons grace can't reach you? Whose handwriting is it — yours, or God's?

Prayer: Lord, make me new in Christ; let the old pass away and the new come, starting today. Amen.

Hope That Overflows

Weekly Lesson — Episode 3: "Abounding Hope" · The Hope Connection, Season 1

The passage:

> "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope." — Romans 15:13 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. Hope's source is a Person, not a circumstance. When your future feels uncertain, it is easy to treat hope like a supply that runs low — some days the cup looks full, and some days it looks empty. But Paul does not call God the God of *some* hope, or the God of barely-enough. He calls Him "the God of hope." Hope begins with who God is, not with how your week is going. Biblical hope is not wishful thinking, and it is not ordinary optimism dressed in church clothes. Optimism depends on circumstances trending your way. Biblical hope trusts the God who cannot fail — which means it can stand in a season where nothing looks hopeful yet.

And notice who this hope is for. It is not reserved for people who have everything figured out. It is for the weary, the wandering, and the wondering — people carrying heavy burdens, questioning their next steps, or simply exhausted. Abounding hope does not require you to clean yourself up or pretend you're fine before you receive it. It invites you to come as you are, right where you are, and be filled there.

2. Joy and peace come "in believing." Read the verse in order: God fills you with joy and peace *in believing* — as you trust Him. Joy and peace are not prizes for people whose problems have ended; they are the filling of people who are believing in the middle of problems that have not. That is the honest order of it. You do not wait for the uncertain future to settle before you are allowed peace. You trust the God who holds the future, and the peace comes as part of the trusting — before the answer arrives, before the diagnosis, before the door opens or closes. Believing is not pretending everything is fine. It is deciding that God is.

3. The Spirit makes hope *abound*. The verse ends with a word worth slowing down for: *abound*. It means to overflow — to exist in more than enough. And abounding is not something you work up; it happens "by the power of the Holy Spirit." God does not give just enough hope to survive the day. He gives enough to overflow — enough that a weary person becomes a steadying person, and hope spills into the people around them. Like an anchor for the soul (Hebrews 6:19), this hope holds steady precisely because it is fastened to Someone outside the storm. Your part is believing. His part is the filling and the overflowing — and He is good at His part.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. Where does your hope usually come from — circumstances going well, your own strength, or the character of God? How can you tell?
2. 2. The verse puts joy and peace "in believing," before circumstances change. Is there an uncertain place in your life where you can practice trusting God there first?
3. 3. Who around you is running low on hope? What would it look like for your overflow to reach them this week — a word, a prayer, a story of what God has done?

Closing prayer:

Father, You are the God of hope — not the God of barely enough. When our futures feel uncertain, teach us to anchor in who You are instead of how things look. Fill us with all joy and peace in believing, and by the power of Your Holy Spirit make our hope abound until it overflows onto the people around us. Hold us steady like an anchor in deep water. In Jesus' name, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Episode 3 — Daily Lessons

Daily 1 — More Than a Wish

From Episode 3: "Abounding Hope"

> "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope." — Romans 15:13 (ESV)

When your future feels uncertain, hope is more than a wish. A wish is a hope with no ground under it — fingers crossed, waiting to see. Biblical hope is different: it is confident trust in the God who cannot fail. Notice that Paul calls Him "the God of hope." Hope is not something we scrape together on good days; it belongs to who God is, and He gives it to people who trust Him. Even in a heavy season — *especially* in a heavy season — hope has a foundation that circumstances cannot shake.

Question: Is your hope today more of a wish or a trust? What is it resting on?

Prayer: God of hope, teach me to trust You instead of just wishing things were different. Amen.

Daily 2 — Filled, Not Just Topped Up

From Episode 3: "Abounding Hope"

> "You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows." — Psalm 23:5 (ESV)

David's cup did not just reach the brim — it overflowed, and it overflowed at a table set "in the presence of my enemies," not after they left. That is how God gives hope. He does not hand out just enough to survive the day and hope you make it to tomorrow. He fills, and then He keeps pouring. Maybe today your cup honestly feels drained. The answer is not to guard the last drops more carefully. The answer is to come back to the One who fills — and to notice that He has a habit of filling cups in the middle of trouble, not only after it.

Question: Where does your hope feel most drained right now? Have you brought that empty place to God plainly, and asked Him to fill it?

Prayer: Lord, my cup feels low today; fill it again, and let it overflow even before my circumstances change. Amen.

Daily 3 — Hope Holds Like an Anchor

From Episode 3: "Abounding Hope"

> "We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain." — Hebrews 6:19 (ESV)

An anchor does its work underwater, out of sight, in exactly the conditions that frighten sailors. That is the picture Scripture gives of hope in Christ: "a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul." A boat does not need calm water to be anchored — it needs the anchor to hold in rough water. Your feelings will rise and fall with the weather; that is normal, and it is not the measure of your hope. The measure is what your soul is fastened to. Fastened to Christ, hope holds even when you cannot see it holding.

Question: When the water gets rough, what do you usually fasten your soul to — and how steady is it, really?

Prayer: Jesus, anchor my soul in You today; hold me steady in water I cannot calm. Amen.

Daily 4 — Joy and Peace *in Believing*

From Episode 3: "Abounding Hope"

> "Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid." — John 14:27 (ESV)

God fills His people with joy and peace "in believing" — while they trust, not after everything resolves. That order matters. The world gives peace the other way around: peace when the scan is clear, the bill is paid, the relationship is mended. Jesus gives a different kind — peace handed over in advance, in the middle of the night, before anyone knows how the story ends. "Let not your hearts be troubled" is not a scolding to people who feel afraid. It is an invitation to receive a peace that does not wait for permission from your circumstances.

Question: What are you waiting to have settled before you will let yourself have peace? What would trusting Jesus *there*, first, look like?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, give me Your peace — not the world's kind — and teach my troubled heart to rest in You. Amen.

Daily 5 — Overflow Is Meant to Be Shared

From Episode 3: "Abounding Hope"

> "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our affliction, so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God." — 2 Corinthians 1:3–4 (ESV)

Hope that abounds does not pool in one place — it flows. Paul says God comforts us in our affliction *so that* we can comfort others with the same comfort. Your hard season is not wasted material; in God's hands it becomes somebody else's lifeline. The encouragement that carried you through a dark month may be exactly the sentence that carries a friend through theirs. You do not need a platform or a perfect story. You need only to pass on, honestly, the hope that was given to you.

Question: Who in your life is carrying something you have carried before? What comfort that God gave you could you pass to them this week?

Prayer: Father of mercies, comfort me today — and make my life a channel of Your comfort to somebody else. Amen.

Not My Will: Surrender in the Garden

Weekly Lesson — Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?" · Surrender (series opener)

The passage:

> "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done." — Luke 22:42 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. Jesus was honest before He was surrendered. The night before the cross, in a garden called Gethsemane, the Son of God knelt and prayed a real request from a real human heart: "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me." He knew exactly what the cup held — betrayal, mocking, nails, and underneath it all, the full weight of God's wrath against sin. Luke says He was in agony; His sweat became like great drops of blood. So learn this first: surrender does not begin with pretending you are fine. Surrender is not the absence of struggle. It is what happens in the middle of it. You are allowed to tell God the truth about what you fear before you hand it over.

2. Surrender is a handing over, not a giving up. The New Testament keeps reaching for one Greek word: *paradidōmi* — to hand over, to deliver up, to place into another's hands. It is the word for Christ, who "gave himself" for us (Galatians 2:20); for Jesus, who kept "entrusting himself to him who judges justly" (1 Peter 2:23); and for the Father, who "gave him up for us all" (Romans 8:32). Giving up is dropping something because you cannot hold it anymore. Giving *over* is placing it — deliberately, while you still have the strength to hold on — into hands stronger and better than yours. A white flag says, "You beat me." Surrender to God says, "I was never meant to carry this — and I know the One who is." And it is safe to open your hands to Him, because you are not handing your life to a stranger: He handed Himself over for you first.

3. The help comes after the surrender — and surrender is daily. Notice the order in the garden: an angel came and strengthened Jesus *after* the surrender, not before it. God did not make the garden easy and then ask. Jesus surrendered in the dark, and the help met Him there. Peace is the fruit of surrender; it is not the price of admission. And because Paul calls our surrender a "living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1), it has to be offered again every morning — a living sacrifice keeps trying to crawl off the altar. So the marks are simple: open hands first thing; "not my will" prayed *before* the decision, not after it; and obedience in the next small thing. Stack those days for a year, and you will not recognize the person you were.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. Is there a prayer you have been afraid to pray honestly — your own "remove this cup"? What would it mean to say it to the Father out loud, the way Jesus did?
2. 2. Think of the thing your hands are still closed around. Have you been *giving up* on it in despair, or could you *give it over* in trust? What is the difference for you?
3. 3. Which of the three marks is hardest for you right now — the morning handover, praying before the decision, or the one small obedience? What is the next small thing?

Closing prayer:

Father, we come to You the way Your Son came to You in the garden — honestly, and out of road. You know the things we have been clutching, and the years we have spent calling our own way freedom while it chained us. Today we stop negotiating. Not our will, but Yours, be done — in our lives, in our families, in the things we are most afraid to hand You. We believe Your hands are good, because we have seen what they bore for us at the cross. Strengthen us the way You strengthened Your Son: after the surrender, in the dark, for the road ahead. In Jesus' name, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Episode 4 — Daily Lessons

Daily 1 — Honest First

From Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?"

> "Trust in him at all times, O people; pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us." — Psalm 62:8 (ESV)

Surrender did not begin with Jesus pretending He was fine. In the garden, the Son of God prayed a real request — "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me" — before He prayed, "Not my will, but yours." Honesty came first. That order is a mercy for us. You do not have to tidy up your fear, your grief, or your dread before you bring it to God. Pour out your heart before Him, exactly as it is. The God who heard His own Son's honest prayer in the dark is not put off by yours.

Question: What is the honest sentence you have been afraid to pray? Can you say it to the Father today, out loud?

Prayer: Father, I pour out my heart before You today — no pretending — and I trust You with what I fear. Amen.

Daily 2 — Giving Over Is Not Giving Up

From Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?"

> "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." — Galatians 2:20 (ESV)

There is a world of difference between giving up and giving over. Giving up is dropping something because you cannot hold it anymore — despair with open hands. Giving over is placing it, on purpose, while you still have the strength to hold on, into hands stronger and better than yours. That is the Bible's own picture of surrender: the Son of God "loved me and gave himself for me." Surrender to God is not defeat. A white flag says, "You beat me." Surrender to God says, "I was never meant to carry this — and I know the One who is."

Question: The thing you are most tired of carrying — have you dropped it in despair, or handed it over in trust? What would handing it over look like today?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, You gave Yourself for me; teach me to hand my life over to You on purpose, not just drop it in defeat. Amen.

Daily 3 — Every One to His Own Way

From Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?"

> "All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned — every one — to his own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all." — Isaiah 53:6 (ESV)

Isaiah describes all of us in one sentence: every one turned to his own way. Not everybody struggles the same way — but everybody has a "my way" they protect, a part of life where God may have almost anything, as long as He does not touch the controls. Lewis protected his way for more than thirty years, and it charged him dearly. But read the verse to the end: the story does not stop at our wandering. "The LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all." Our waywardness was carried by Jesus. That is why going back is possible — for anyone.

Question: What is your "own way" — the area where you most resist God's say? What has it cost you so far?

Prayer: Father, I confess my own way; thank You that my iniquity was laid on Jesus, and turn me back to Yours. Amen.

Daily 4 — He Handed Himself Over First

From Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?"

> "He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" — Romans 8:32 (ESV)

Here is why surrender is safe: you are not being asked to hand your life over to a stranger. Before God ever asked for your surrender, He went first — the Father did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, and the Son handed Himself over in the garden and on the cross. The hands you would be handing your life to are hands that were pierced holding the cup you could not drink. A sinner can open his hands without being destroyed, because the hands receiving him have already borne everything surrender was afraid of.

Question: When you picture handing your life to God, whose hands do you picture? How does the cross change that picture?

Prayer: Father, You gave up Your own Son for me; I can trust Your hands with my life. Amen.

Daily 5 — A Living Sacrifice Crawls Off the Altar

From Episode 4: "What Does Real Surrender Actually Look Like?"

> "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me." — Luke 9:23 (ESV)

Jesus said the cross is *daily*. Paul calls our surrender a "living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1) — and a living sacrifice, unlike a dead one, has to be offered again every morning, because it keeps trying to crawl off the altar. So if you surrendered yesterday and woke up today clutching the controls again, you are not a failure. You are a living sacrifice. Offer it again. That is the normal Christian life: open hands first thing, before the phone, before the news, before your feelings hold their first meeting. A morning decision saves you a hundred afternoon ones.

Question: What did you hand over yesterday that your hands are holding again this morning? Can you offer it once more, before the day gets voted on?

Prayer: Lord, I offer myself to You again this morning — my will, my plans, my day. Keep my hands open. Amen.

The Grip: Why We Won't Open Our Hands

Weekly Lesson — Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over" · Surrender series

The passage:

> "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done." — Luke 22:42 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. The object changes; the grip is the same. Everybody told Lewis to surrender — judges, counselors, the people who loved him — and every time, something in him dug its heels in, because in his world surrender was what losers did. Maybe your grip is not a needle or a bottle. It may be a plan you cannot release, a picture of how life was supposed to go that you hold tighter the less life cooperates. It may be a person you cannot stop trying to fix, where letting go feels like not loving them. Or it may be fear, managed twelve ways a day — the lists, the backups, the worst-case rehearsals at two in the morning. Three different grips, one closed hand. We call it being responsible, being strong, being a fighter. Underneath, most of the time, it is simpler — and harder to admit.

2. The real issue is trust. Here is the whole episode in one line: the reason a person will not open their hands is not usually that their hands are strong. It is that they do not yet trust the hands they would be falling into. Lewis believed God was real — he had heard about Him since childhood in his grandmother's church — but believing God is real and trusting God with the controls are two very different things. So he held on, and ran the one life he knew into the ground, one year at a time, for three decades. And he is clear that God did not make surrender a fair-weather decision: in the garden, the angel who strengthened Jesus arrived *after* the surrender, not before. The help meets us in the dark, on the far side of open hands.

3. The hands were pierced first — so opening ours is safe. You are not handing your life to a stranger, a system, or a statistic. The God who asks for your surrender went first: "he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross" (Philippians 2:8). The hands receiving you held the cup you could not drink. That is also why a late handover is not a late handover to God. He is not standing there with a watch. He is standing there with pierced hands and heaven's patience, saying: *finally — now we can begin.* Lewis was the thirty-years-late man, and "finally," from God's side, felt like joy. The Reformers said it in four words: *let God be God.* Not advisor, not backup plan — God. And you, finally, glad to be held.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. Which grip is yours — the plan, the person, or the fear? (Or another one entirely?) What exactly are your hands closed around?
2. 2. Be honest: is your resistance to surrender really about strength, or about trust? Whose hands do you picture yourself falling into — and where did that picture come from?
3. 3. Surrender is a morning prayer with a name in it: *Father, not my will, but Yours, be done*, prayed over one named thing for seven mornings. What is the name you would put in that prayer?

Closing prayer:

Father, we come to You honestly, the way Your Son came to You in the garden. You know the things we have been clutching, and the years we spent calling our grip strength when it was fear — fear of falling into hands we did not trust. But we have seen those hands now, pierced for us at the cross. So we hand it over, by name: the plan, the person, the fear, the part of life with our name on the door. Not our will, but Yours, be done. And for the one still in the middle of the struggle, meet them in the dark the way You met Your Son, and strengthen them on the far side of open hands. In Jesus' name, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Episode 5 — Daily Lessons

Daily 1 — The Plan You Can't Release

From Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over"

> "The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps." — Proverbs 16:9 (ESV)

You have a picture of how your life was supposed to go. It was a good picture. And life has not cooperated. Instead of grieving it and handing it over, it is easy to grip the picture tighter — as if holding it hard enough could make the years reprint it. But a plan held in a closed fist becomes a weight, not a guide. Your heart will plan; that is what hearts do. The mercy is that the LORD establishes the steps. Hand Him the picture. He is better at the road than the photograph of it.

Question: What plan are you gripping hardest right now? What would grieving it — and handing it over — actually look like?

Prayer: Lord, I hand You the picture of how my life was supposed to go; establish my steps on the road that is real. Amen.

Daily 2 — Handing a Person to God Is Not Abandoning Them

From Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over"

> "Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved." — Psalm 55:22 (ESV)

Somebody you love is on a road that scares you, and you have appointed yourself their rescuer. You check, you fix, you carry, you lie awake doing a job that was never posted — because letting go of them feels like not loving them. Hear this plainly: handing a person to God is not abandoning them. It is admitting who their Savior actually is — and it is not you. You can love them, pray for them, and tell them the truth, all with open hands. The carrying was never yours to do.

Question: Who have you been trying to rescue in your own strength? What is one way you can love them this week with open hands instead of a grip?

Prayer: Father, I hand You the person I love and cannot fix; sustain me, and do for them what only You can. Amen.

Daily 3 — A Fortress With the Prisoner Inside

From Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over"

> "Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed, for I am your God; I will strengthen you, I will help you, I will uphold you with my righteous right hand." — Isaiah 41:10 (ESV)

Fear can run a whole life quietly: the lists, the backups, the worst-case rehearsals at two in the morning. Managing fear feels like wisdom. But a life arranged around never having to trust God is not wisdom — it is a fortress with the prisoner inside. God's word to frightened people is never "manage it better." It is "I am with you… I will uphold you." The way out of the fortress is not a bigger wall. It is the presence of the God who holds you up with His own hand.

Question: What does your fear-management look like — and what fear is it really guarding? Can you name it to God today?

Prayer: Lord, I am afraid, and You are with me; uphold me with Your righteous right hand today. Amen.

Daily 4 — The Decision Goes First; Feelings Report Later

From Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over"

> "For we walk by faith, not by sight." — 2 Corinthians 5:7 (ESV)

Surrender is not a feeling you wait for. If Lewis had waited to *feel* surrendered, he says, he would still be waiting — and still be using. In the garden, Jesus surrendered in the middle of the struggle, as a decision: "Not my will, but yours" — before He felt any better, while His friends slept a stone's throw away. The decision goes first. The feelings report in later, if they report at all. So do not measure today's faithfulness by today's emotions. Walk by faith: make the surrendered decision in the dark, and let God handle the weather inside you.

Question: What surrendered decision have you been postponing until you feel ready? What is the decision itself, in one sentence?

Prayer: Father, I choose Your will before I feel it; teach me to walk by faith and not by sight today. Amen.

Daily 5 — Thirty Years Late Is Not Late to God

From Episode 5: "Surrender, Part 1: Not Giving Up — Giving Over"

> "But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him." — Luke 15:20 (ESV)

For the one who thinks they have waited too long: the hands do not get tired of being opened to. A handover thirty years late is not a late handover to God. He is not standing there with a watch; He is standing there with pierced hands and the whole of heaven's patience. Jesus pictured the Father of the prodigal the same way — not waiting on the porch with crossed arms, but running, while the son was still a long way off. Lewis was the thirty-years-late man, and from God's side, "finally" felt like joy. It is not too late. It was never going to be too late.

Question: What have you told yourself it is "too late" for? What does the running Father say to that sentence?

Prayer: Father, thank You that I am not too late for You; I come now, and I trust the hands that receive me. Amen.

Leave It With Him: Learning to Stop Picking the Burden Back Up

Weekly Lesson — Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony" · The Hope Connection

The passage:

> "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." — Matthew 11:28 (ESV)

> "Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you." — 1 Peter 5:6–7 (ESV)

The teaching:

1. Some burdens start in childhood — and God sees every one of them. Rachel's story begins in Denver: a little girl whose mother was lost to mental illness and then to suicide, who slept on a couch after the move to Oregon, who at twelve was cleaning cabins, taking reservations, and collecting rent at a trailer park — while carrying verbal and emotional abuse at home and being told she was a burden. Then came more: a brother lost, a sister murdered, a father's long illness and death, abusive relationships, years of school squeezed around raising two boys, and a body that broke down after the move to West Virginia. She names it plainly: "some of you are tired — maybe bone tired; that kind of tired that isn't just from a long day, it's from a long season." If that is you, her story says first: your burden is real, it has a history, and God has never once overlooked it.

2. Laying it down is a practice, not a one-time event. Here is the heart of her testimony, in her own words: "It isn't that God gives me blessings and takes them away. It's that I lay my burdens at His feet, then pick them right back up again." You may know exactly what that looks like: you pray about the bills, then lie awake doing the math anyway. You ask God to heal a relationship, then rehearse the argument. You say, "Lord, I trust You," and carry it all day like it is still yours to fix. Rachel's breakthrough was not that her problems vanished: "He didn't take my storm away. He taught me to be still in it." And when she catches herself picking a burden back up — "some days I hand the same burden back ten times, and that's okay. God has never once told me I was only allowed to bring it to Him once."

3. He doesn't remove the road; He renews your strength for it. Rachel holds onto Isaiah 40:31 — those who wait on the LORD renew their strength, run and not be weary, walk and not faint — and she reads it carefully: "Notice it doesn't say God takes the road away. It says He renews your strength for the road you're on." That is the hope she offers: not a life with the burdens edited

out, but a Savior standing with you in the storm — "I'm standing in my storm, not because I'm strong, but because He is." Jesus' invitation is not "come when you have it all together." It is for right now, exactly as tired as you are.

Questions to sit with:

1. 1. What is the burden you have been carrying the longest — maybe since you were young? Have you ever told God its whole history, out loud?
2. 2. Where do you most notice yourself "picking it back up" — the nighttime math, the rehearsed argument, the all-day carrying? What happens in you in that moment?
3. 3. Rachel says God never limited her to bringing a burden once. How does that change the way you pray about the thing you have already prayed about a hundred times?

Closing prayer:

Lord, we lift up every person carrying a long-season burden today — the weight they have carried since they were young, the nights they have lain awake wondering how much longer they can hold it all together. Meet them in it, the way You met Rachel in hers. Teach them to lay it at Your feet and leave it with You — and when they pick it back up, give them grace to hand it back again without shame. Teach them to be still in the storm. Give them Your rest, the kind the world cannot give. Remind them they never have to carry it alone — not one single day. In Jesus' name, amen.

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

Bonus Special — Daily Lessons (Rachel's "My Story")

Daily 1 — Bone Tired Is a Real Place

From the Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony"

> "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." — Matthew 11:28 (ESV)

Rachel opens her story with a kind of tired many people know and few can name: "bone tired — that kind of tired that isn't just from a long day, it's from a long season." Years of carrying: family lost young, work no child should have carried, grief stacked on grief. Jesus' words were spoken to exactly that person. "Come to me" is not a suggestion, Rachel says — it is an invitation, and it is not "come when you have it all together." It is for right now, exactly as tired as you are.

Question: Is your tiredness from a long day or a long season? What would it mean to bring the whole season to Jesus, not just today?

Prayer: Lord Jesus, I am bone tired; I come to You exactly as I am, and I receive Your rest. Amen.

Daily 2 — Lay It Down — Again

From the Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony"

> "Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you." — 1 Peter 5:7 (ESV)

Rachel's honest discovery: "I lay my burdens at His feet, then pick them right back up again." You pray about the bills, then lie awake doing the math. You say, "Lord, I trust You," then carry it all day like it is still yours to fix. Her word for today is grace for the repetition: "Some days I hand the same burden back ten times, and that's okay. God has never once told me I was only allowed to bring it to Him once." He just keeps taking it, every single time you are willing to let it go.

Question: Which burden did you hand to God — and quietly pick back up? Can you hand it back once more right now, without scolding yourself?

Prayer: Father, here it is again — the same burden. Thank You that You never tire of taking it from me. Amen.

Daily 3 — Still in the Storm

From the Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony"

> "'Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!' The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress." — Psalm 46:10–11 (ESV)

For years Rachel wondered why God allowed the stress and burden to keep bringing her to exhaustion. Then came the turn: "He didn't take my storm away. He taught me to be still in it. He taught me to stop reacting and start trusting Him." The psalm does not promise the nations stop raging; it promises the LORD of hosts is *with us* in the middle of it. Some storms God calms. Others, He teaches us to stand in — not because we are strong, but because He is standing with us.

Question: Have you been asking God only to end the storm? What might He be teaching you about being still in it?

Prayer: Lord of hosts, be with me in this storm; teach me to be still and to know that You are God. Amen.

Daily 4 — Strength for the Road You're On

From the Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony"

> "But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint." — Isaiah 40:31 (ESV)

Rachel reads this promise with care: "Notice it doesn't say God takes the road away. It says He renews your strength for the road you're on." Most of the Christian life is not flying; it is walking — ordinary days, ordinary duties, carried one at a time. The promise covers even that: they shall *walk* and not faint. Waiting on the LORD is not doing nothing. It is the active trust of a person who keeps coming back to God for the strength each stretch of road requires — and finds it there, every time.

Question: What stretch of ordinary road is wearing you down most? What would waiting on the LORD for *that* road look like this week?

Prayer: Lord, renew my strength for the road I am actually on; help me walk today and not faint. Amen.

Daily 5 — God Doesn't Waste Your Pain

From the Bonus Special: "My Story: Rachel's Testimony"

> "And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose." — Romans 8:28 (ESV)

"Romans 8:28 is real," Rachel says. "He works all things for good — even the cracks in the floor, the mess you didn't make, even the tire[dness]." Her life holds losses no one would choose — and yet she can stand and say God pulled her through, and that if He can pull her through hers, He can pull you through yours. All things working together for good does not mean all things *are* good. It means none of it is wasted in His hands — not the grief, not the damage, not the years that felt lost.

Question: What painful chapter have you assumed was simply wasted? What would you say to God about it if you believed He wastes nothing?

Prayer: Father, I trust that You work all things together for good; take even the painful chapters and waste none of them. Amen.